



WE WILL CUT OFF HIS HEAD WITH THE CROWN UPON IT

THE EXECUTION OF CHARLES I (1649)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

English Civil War

BEFORE

1639 English and Scottish forces clash in the first “Bishops’ War.”

1642 The Civil War begins at Edgehill, Warwickshire.

1645 Oliver Cromwell’s “New Model Army” scores victories at Naseby and Langport.

1646 Charles is forced to surrender to his opponents.

AFTER

1649 The Commonwealth of England (a republic) is formed.

1653 Cromwell takes the title Lord Protector for Life, giving him the power to call or dissolve parliaments.

1658 Cromwell dies and is succeeded as Protector by his son, Richard.

1660 The monarchy is restored: Charles II becomes King of England.

During the 1640s, England was plunged into a series of wars, fought to decide the future of the country and known collectively as the English Civil War. On one side were the Royalists—predominantly landed gentry and aristocrats who supported King Charles I and his right to rule independently of parliament. On the

King Charles I asserts his **divine right to rule**.

The king needs to **raise taxes** to pay for wars.

Parliament attempts to **limit the king’s authority**. A **civil war** erupts between Crown and parliament for the **right to rule**.

Parliamentary forces, led by Cromwell, **win the war**.

The king is executed and an English republic is instituted.

other were the Parliamentarians—mainly smaller landowners and tradesmen, many of whom held Puritan beliefs and disliked Charles’s autocratic stance. By 1648, the Parliamentarians had beaten Charles on the battlefield and Oliver Cromwell, their leader, ejected from parliament all those who were prepared to negotiate with the king, leaving the remainder (known as the Rump Parliament) to vote to end the monarchy. Charles was tried for treason against England and was beheaded in 1649, after which England began an 11-year period as a republic.

The causes of war

King Charles I and parliament were natural opponents. Charles was sympathetic to Catholics while parliament was Protestant,